MODULE 40 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

The MLA-C01 bridge

What is different, what this course covers anyway, and what it leaves out.

MODULE 40 of 43 DOMAIN Exam skills WEIGHT C01 only

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MLA-C01 in English retires on 28 September 2026. The other languages run longer.

Should you sit C01 or C02?

- **Both certifications carry the same name and the same value.** Neither is worth more.
- **C01 if** you are ready now, prepared on it, and can sit before the retirement date.
- **C02 beta if** you want the current syllabus, and can accept a longer wait for results.
- **C02 at general availability** from January 2027, with normal scoring and prompt results.
- If your preparation is C02-shaped, sitting C01 means learning three dropped topics for nothing.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The honest answer for most people reading this course: you prepared for C02, so sit C02.

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C01 and C02 compared

	MLA-C01	MLA-C02
Questions	50 scored, 15 unscored	Same at GA. 85 in beta
Duration and pass	170 minutes, 720	Same
Question types	Five, including ordering and matching	Two only
Domain weights	28 / 26 / 22 / 24	28 / 24 / 24 / 24
Generative AI	Present, and lighter	Substantially expanded
Dropped topics	Neo, BYOC, model compression	Not in scope

ON THE EXAM

The structure is identical: four domains, twelve task statements, mapped one to one. AWS publishes the comparison.

Two points moved

- **C01: Data 28, Modelling 26, Deployment 22, Monitoring 24.**
- **C02: Data 28, Modelling 24, Deployment 24, Monitoring 24.**
- Two points moved from modelling to deployment. That is the whole difference.
- It is not enough to change how you revise. Both exams are near enough flat.
- Compensatory scoring applies to both, so breadth still beats depth.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A two-point shift is roughly one question. It is worth knowing and not worth planning around.

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C01 has three question types that C02 does not, and they are scored differently.

Ordering questions

- A list of **three to five responses**, which you select and place in the correct order.
- They test **procedural** knowledge: what happens first, and what depends on what.
- Think in dependencies. Something cannot be evaluated before it is trained.
- The pipeline order from module 28 is the archetype: process, train, evaluate, gate, register.
- Partial credit is not something to rely on. Get the whole sequence right.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Almost every ordering question in this domain is a variation on a workflow this course already taught in order.

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Matching questions

- A list of responses to match against **three to seven prompts**.
- **You must match all pairs correctly to receive credit.** Six of seven scores nothing.
- So the technique is: place the ones you are certain of, then use elimination on the rest.
- Module 37's pair tables are close to ideal preparation for these.
- A confident match removes that response from every other prompt. Use that.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> All-or-nothing scoring makes elimination more valuable here than anywhere else on the exam.

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Case study questions

- One scenario, with **multiple questions** asked against it.
- **Each question is evaluated separately**, and you get credit for each one you answer correctly.
- So a case study is far more forgiving than matching. One wrong answer costs one mark.
- Read the scenario carefully once, because you will use it several times.
- Budget accordingly: a five-question case study is five questions, not one.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The independent scoring is the good news. Do not let one hard question in a case study unsettle the others.

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In C01, not in C02

TOPIC	WHY C01 TESTS IT
SageMaker Neo	Compiling a model for specific target hardware, including edge devices
Bring your own container	Building a custom container to the SageMaker AI contract
Model compression and pruning	Reducing model size by removing weights

ON THE EXAM

Three topics, and each is a single concept rather than a domain. An hour on all three is enough for C01.

SageMaker Neo

- Compiles a trained model for a **specific target hardware platform**.
- The point was **edge deployment**: running a model on a device rather than an endpoint.
- It optimises for that target's instruction set and memory, improving speed and footprint.
- Paired with **IoT Greengrass** for deploying and managing the model on devices.
- In C02 the equivalent is **compilation in the inference optimization toolkit**. Module 22.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If a C01 question mentions edge devices, intermittent connectivity or a hardware target, Neo and Greengrass are the pairing it wants.

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Bring your own container

- Building a Docker image that satisfies the SageMaker AI contract: **/ping and /invocations**.
- The reason to do it: a framework or dependency AWS does not provide a container for.
- The model artefact is still downloaded from S3 to a known path inside the container.
- Push to **ECR**, reference the image URI in the model definition, and deploy as normal.
- C02 dropped it because prebuilt and extended containers cover almost every real case.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Module 21 taught the contract itself, which is the examinable part. C01 additionally expects you to know you can build to it.

Model compression and pruning

- **Pruning** removes weights that contribute little, making the model smaller and faster.
- It usually costs some accuracy, and often requires fine-tuning afterwards to recover it.
- The motivation is the same as quantization: a smaller model, on smaller hardware.
- **Distillation** is the related idea C02 kept: train a small model to imitate a large one. Module 11.
- C02 kept quantization and distillation, and dropped pruning specifically.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Three ways to make a model smaller: remove weights, reduce precision, or train a smaller one. C01 tests all three; C02 tests two.

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What C02 added that C01 does not test

- **Bedrock Knowledge Bases, Guardrails, Prompt Management, Custom Model Import, Evaluations.**
- **AgentCore, including its observability**, and CloudWatch generative AI observability.
- So if you are sitting C01, several modules of this course are **more depth than you need**.
- Generative AI is still present in C01, and lighter. Do not skip it entirely.
- Reading those modules will not hurt you. It is simply not where your revision time earns most.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The overlap is far larger than the difference. This course over-prepares a C01 candidate rather than under-preparing them.

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How a C01 candidate should use this course

MODULES	HOW TO TREAT THEM
01 to 11, Domain 1	In full. Data preparation is 28 percent in both exams
12 to 19, Domain 2	In full. Slightly heavier in C01 at 26 percent
20 to 28, Domain 3	In full, and note that C01 weights it two points lighter
29 to 36, Domain 4	In full
16, 18, 25 to 27	Read rather than memorise. Deepest on C02-only material
37 to 39	In full. Format advice differs only on question types
This module	Plus the three dropped topics above

ON THE EXAM

There is no module a C01 candidate should skip. There are a few where the depth exceeds what C01 asks for.

The maintenance flags apply to you too

- The ten features from module 38 are closed to new customers **regardless of which exam you sit**.
- C01 names several of them, including Ground Truth, Clarify, Model Monitor and Role Manager.
- **Answer C01 questions with the named service**, exactly as module 38 advised for C02.
- C01 also covers A2I and Ground Truth more heavily, so this affects you more, not less.
- Module 38 applies unchanged. Nothing in it is C02-specific.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The maintenance wave is about the platform, not about a syllabus. It affects both exams identically.

The overlap is **most of both exams**. Learn the three dropped topics and the three extra formats.

> A C01 question describes a manufacturer deploying a defect-detection model onto cameras in a factory. The devices have limited memory and intermittent network connectivity, and inference must run locally.
>
> The question asks how to prepare and deploy the model.

What should the answer involve?

A. A multi-model endpoint, with one model per camera

B. Compile with SageMaker Neo for the target hardware, and deploy with IoT Greengrass

C. Asynchronous inference, so the cameras can queue requests

D. Serverless inference, which scales to zero between detections

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the answer involve?

A. A multi-model endpoint, with one model per camera

An endpoint runs in AWS. The scenario states inference must run locally on devices with intermittent connectivity.

B. Compile with SageMaker Neo for the target hardware, and deploy with IoT Greengrass

Neo optimises the model for the device's hardware and limited memory; Greengrass deploys and manages it there. That is the edge pairing C01 tests.

C. Asynchronous inference, so the cameras can queue requests

Still an endpoint in AWS, and it still requires connectivity to submit and collect results.

D. Serverless inference, which scales to zero between detections

Also an endpoint, and cold starts plus intermittent connectivity make it the worst of the three cloud options.

THE SIGNAL

Three signals point at the edge: limited memory, intermittent connectivity, and inference running locally. All three are stated.

> You are sitting MLA-C01 and reach a matching question. It presents six prompts and a list of responses. You are confident about four of the pairings and genuinely unsure about the remaining two.
>
> Time is not yet a pressure. You have about two minutes available.

What should you do?

A. Answer the four you are sure of and leave the other two blank

B. Guess the two immediately, since partial credit will cover the four

C. Skip the question entirely and return at the end

D. Place the four, then use elimination on the remaining responses for the last two

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

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What should you do?

A Answer the four you are sure of and leave the other two blank

All pairs must match to receive credit. Four of six scores exactly the same as zero of six.

B Guess the two immediately, since partial credit will cover the four

The premise is wrong: there is no partial credit on matching. Guessing without eliminating throws away the information you have.

C Skip the question entirely and return at the end

Leaves a question with no answer, and unanswered questions are scored as incorrect. You also have time available.

D Place the four, then use elimination on the remaining responses for the last two

Four confident placements remove four responses from consideration, which often leaves the last two nearly decided. Elimination is free.

THE SIGNAL

All-or-nothing scoring makes elimination worth more here than anywhere else: four certainties are not four marks, they are context for the fifth and sixth.

What to take from this module

- **MLA-C01 in English retires 28 September 2026.** Other languages run to C02 GA.
- **Three extra question types:** ordering, matching, case study.
- **Matching is all-or-nothing.** Case study scores each question independently.
- **Three dropped topics:** SageMaker Neo, bring your own container, model pruning.
- **Everything else in this course applies unchanged**, and often in more depth than C01 needs.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Modules 41 to 43 are sixty practice questions. They use C02 formats, and the content applies to both exams.

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